

The Auto Pilots

What would you expect from a guy who drives an autorickshaw to work? A unique three-wheeler rally that combines adventure with social responsibility.



A RICKSHAW RALLY IN PROGRESS

| By Nandini Vaish |

Aravind Bremanandam, 32, an autorickshaw enthusiast, wants his passion for the “national vehicle” to go global. In 2006, this proud owner of 40 autos began a rally called the Rickshaw Challenge where he provided autos to teams. The participants—most of them foreigners— included a 70-year-old woman from Canada, a male porn star from the UK, a former Miss Hungary, an actor from Japan and a competitor with a prosthetic leg. About 20-30 teams signed up for the nine-day race from Chennai to Kanyakumari.

The Rickshaw Challenge continued, and there are other races too now: the Mumbai Express (Chennai to Mumbai, 12 days), the Malabar Rampage (17 days), which traverses the Western Ghats to reach Kerala and the Tech Raid (five days), which is a technological and cultural exploration through Bangalore, Chennai and Hyderabad. He hopes to start a Delhi race—the Rajdhani Express—in 2010. “It’s more of a way for people to see India,” says Bremanandam.

Teams go wild when it comes to names—Tamil

Devils, Curry in a Hurry, Three Men and a TukTuk, Screamin Cheetah Wheelies. Points are given for decoration—the wackier the better. So you have autos styled like rabbits or painted with polka dots, neon flowers, and even dangling pink boas.

The race starts with an orientation programme where participants are taught not just to drive autos, but also how to deal with breakdowns. The participation fee ranges from 1,000 (Rs 67,108) to 1,600 (Rs 1,07,350) euros. The race is, however, not a test of speed. Teams are penalised for driving above 40 kmph.

But it is also a challenge with a conscience. Teams are asked to raise funds from their countries and the money goes to the Adopt-a-Village project. Bremanandam’s initiative has raised Rs 25 lakh so far and he hopes to raise a similar sum in the Mumbai Express which starts on July 31. The self-styled speed demon is often mistaken for a auto driver when he commutes to work in his three-wheeler and is hailed down for a ride by unsuspecting passengers. Little do they know what they’re in for. ■